

Three-Part Breath

Assume a stillness posture, lowering your chin a little as you lift the top of your head. Let your shoulders fall from that upright posture. Close your eyes and observe how your body moves as you breathe. *(Pause 30 seconds)*

The three parts of the body that we use in this mindfulness exercise are the abdomen, the lower rib cage, and the upper chest. As you inhale, first expand the abdomen, then the lower rib cage, and lastly the upper chest. Feel your shoulders expand at the top of the breath, then exhale. Practice that sequence for one minute, inhaling with the abdomen, then the lower rib cage, and, finally, the upper chest. *(Pause 1 minute)*

Now, as you exhale, try to reverse that pattern. Collapse the upper chest under the collar bone first, then the lower rib cage, and lastly the abdomen. Pull your abdomen toward your spine as you exhale, but do not exhale completely. Stop short of empty so that you do not feel the need to gasp for air. Try that for one minute. *(Pause 1 minute)*

For the next minute, try combining both the three-part inhale and the three-part exhale. *(Pause 1 minute)*

You might explore a solid, confident pause at the top of the inhale and another pause at the bottom of the exhale. Stop short of a full inhale or exhale. Notice when you feel compelled to breathe or when you feel strain or anxiety. This exercise helps you explore how you breathe, and also teaches you how to manage limitations. Practice for one minute. *(Pause 1 minute)*

Continue to practice for another minute. When you inhale, try to smooth out the transitions from the abdomen to the lower rib cage, and from the lower rib cage to the upper chest. When you exhale, practice smoothing out the transitions in the reverse. You might imagine the breath flowing like a wave through your body. *(Pause 1 minute)*

Now return to relaxed and quiet breathing as you observe what is going on inside your skin. *(Pause 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath. Open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting. You might practice the **Three-Part Breath** for a few minutes during your personal meditation time.
(Meeting notes 37)